MUSIC

ALL THE WORLD'S A STAGE

Never more in vogue, the **big-ticket international music collaboration** comes with its perks and pitfalls



In early June, Ed Sheeran dropped a remix of his cloying wedding-rap anthem '2Step' that featured a verse by Indian singer-songwriter Armaan Malik. This was Malik's second international collaboration, following his 2021 single 'Echo', which featured indie K-pop star Eric Nam and Indo-American producer KSHMR. Having already established himself as a popular playback singer at home, the 26-year-old is now looking to break out onto the global pop music scene. His weapon of choice, it appears, is the international pop collaboration.

He's not the only one. In May, Badshah dropped 'Voodoo', a collaboration with the Colombian 'Prince of Reggaeton' J. Balvin. Last month, he followed it up with a remix that also features popular Atlanta rapper Lil Baby. Diljit Dosanjh, having signed a deal with Warner Music earlier this year, has also announced upcoming singles featuring Canadian rapper Tory Lanez and Tanzanian bongo flava star Diamond Platnumz.

This isn't exactly a novel development. Big labels are always looking for new ways to expand their audiences. Of late, they have adopted the international collab as a major prong of their strategy to take Indian pop global (some would argue that it seems to be the only prong). The shift began all the way back in 2011, when Universal Music Group signed a deal with Priyanka Chopra to release her debut music album on the world stage.

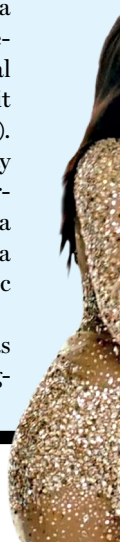
The logic of the deal was quite simple: With the mag-

MANDAR DEODHAR



FUSION, FISSION Top, Badshah (right) and J. Balvin recently collaborated on the song 'Voodoo'; left, a new remix of Ed Sheeran's '2Step' featured Armaan Malik; inset, Priyanka Chopra's song 'Exotic' (2011) saw her collaborate with Pitbull

Streaming has lowered the curtain on the idea of genres as silos: fans no longer expect artists to stick to a particular sound, and celebrate unique innovation



INDIA PICTURE